Elias Olsson

Content and Level Designer

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Summary

Since 2018 I have designed and scripted content for The Road to 56, a Hearts of Iron IV mod with over 1.5 million Steam subscribers. My work there covers focus trees, seasonal events and fixes for the bugs players report. At PlaygroundSquad I was level designer and quality assurance (QA) tester on two PlayStation 5 projects (one in Unreal Engine 5, one in an in-house engine).

Experience

Content Designer, The Road to 56 (Hearts of Iron IV mod, Clausewitz engine) 2018–present

- Designed and scripted focus tree branches for Wales and the Celtic countries, plus focus paths for the AI.
- Responsible for most of the mod's seasonal and limited-time events, including the 500,000-subscriber celebration and an expanded version for April Fools 2024.
- Helped keep the mod working through major DLC releases, including Man the Guns and No Step Back.
- Triaged bug and crash reports from the mod's Discord and subreddit, and fixed them or passed them on to the right team member.

Gameplay Designer and QA, Team Fortress 2 community maps (seven Mann vs. Machine maps) 2015–2017, 2025

- Wrote at least one mission for every map, and standardised formatting, naming and robot behaviour across all contributors' missions.
- Organised dozens of playtests per map with full six-player teams, recruited through my Steam group of thousands of members.

Game projects

Level Designer and QA, Rocket Rider (PlaygroundSquad, PlayStation 5, Unreal Engine 5, team of 17, 9 weeks) 2024

- Sketched and blocked out level segments using Tokyo street layouts as reference. My opening segment kept most of its layout into the final build.
- Placed combat arenas, collectibles and vending machines, and balanced the enemy waves in each arena.
- Built the vending machine purchase UI with Unreal widgets and Blueprints.
- Took on QA mid-project. Reported crashes in the destruction system and enemy AI, and fixed rail-grind splines and geometry holes myself.

Level Designer and QA, BEETLEBOT (PlaygroundSquad, PlayStation 5, in-house engine, team of 12, 6 weeks) 2023

- Designed level concepts based on real ant colony layouts. One of my blockouts made it into the final game.
- Tuned enemy waves, weapon cooldowns and damage, and XP progression for the final build.
- Tested new fixes in the final days and found level-loading crashes, which were fixed before the deadline.

Gameplay and Level Designer (solo), Orchard (Team Fortress 2 Mann vs. Machine map, Hammer editor, 2 months) 2024

- Built a co-op map where the two robot routes merge mid-map and split again, with flanking paths for the robots.
- Cut the map twice after timing its routes with the fastest class, wrote its missions and ran two playtests with outside players.

Education

PlaygroundSquad, Falun (Game Design) 2023–2025
Two-year higher vocational programme with three game projects, ending with an internship at Tension.

Uppsala estetiska gymnasium, Uppsala (Game Design) 2019–2022

Skills

Level design: blockouts and greyboxing, combat arena layout, enemy wave balancing

Content design: focus trees and seasonal events, Clausewitz scripting, TF2 mission scripting (.pop files), game design documents (GDD)

Quality assurance (QA): playtesting, bug and crash reporting, triaging player bug reports

Tools: Unreal Engine 5 (UE5, Blueprints), Unity, Hammer (Source engine), Photoshop, Trello

Languages: Swedish (native), English (fluent)